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Next Question

No shower was available, but I did have the next best thing. Press conferences. Eight in total, and I was going to be there for all of them. After the success we'd had here, my absence would be noticeable and suspicious. And, since I was going to be there anyway, Steph and I decided I would step into Danni's usual role. Nearly twenty minutes of battle with Cole had earned her the rest of the night off.

We were in for a hell of a time, though. Each individual session was no big deal, but together they were grueling. Like, meat factory grueling. Grind up one fighter, spit her out, then move to the next. As each one ended, Steph and I would stay at the table while the next fighter rotated into the center chair.

The good news was that I never had to leave my seat.

The bad news was that I never got to leave my seat.

The sessions lasted about fifteen minutes each, which left me stuck in the same place for over two hours. I was OK with it, though. Nine finalists. Five champions. Two hours seemed like a small price to pay.

Most of the women came bearing the marks and scars of battle, and the amply bandaged Jennifer Morrison was no exception.

"I'm not really satisfied with it," she said when asked about her performance. "I mean, losing is disappointing, but it was more than that. Keira is the best in the weight class, so I knew I had my work cut out for me. But, I don't know... I just felt I could have done better than this."

It looked like she had more to say, but Steph stepped in first.

"She can do better," she said. "She will do better."

Though it sounded like she was addressing the media, she was looking right at Jen.

"I have to take some of the blame here. I really hadn't prepared Jen for a fight like this. Not that I didn't think she was good enough to compete at this level, but she was still working her way up. I thought we had time, but I sometimes forget how easily a good fighter can suddenly come up against the top competitors at these tournaments."

I recognized the word *blame* as my cue to get involved.

"No one is to blame for anything," I said. "Good fighters need experience to be great. Like it or not, this was an experience for Jen. Probably not the experience she wanted, but..."

That got the group laughing... especially when Jen responded with a slow, steady shake of her head. Like she was tacitly admitting she didn't know how the hell she ended up in the cage with Knightley in the first

place. It was funny, honest and sad, all at the same time. I put my arm around her in a little *poor Jen* gesture, and she leaned her head on my shoulder like, *Yeah. Poor me.*

That kind of realness is what her fans love about her. She doesn't put a lot of effort into maintaining appearances. She got beat up, it sucked and she wasn't afraid to show it. But being willing to lick her wounds in public didn't mean she was giving up. She was overmatched against Keira, but she wouldn't let it stay that way. And neither would we.

"Point is," I continued, "this was maybe too much of a challenge, too quickly. But I think Steph will agree when I say we see Jen differently now. She took a step here we didn't realize she was ready for. Now, we know better. We're going to give her what she needs to reach higher, and we're certainly going to expect more."

It was meant to be staunchly supportive, but Jen got the group laughing again when she leaned into the microphone and said, "Uh, oh. What did I just do to myself?"

There were a few follow-up questions, then we traded one Jen for the other as Jen Lawrence rotated in.

She, too, was dissatisfied with her performance, but Steph was having none of it.

"You were great," she said.

Though she would never belittle a fighter in public, Steph is also known for being somewhat tight-lipped when it comes to open praise. She'll give it to you if she feels you've earned it, but she won't hand it out just to make you feel better. So Jen knew what it meant when she heard it.

Then I added my two cents.

"I totally agree," I said. "In fact, I think you did more than enough to get the win."

A bit of a chill spread through the room as some wondered if I was headed for a full-blown controversy. Even Steph gave me a look like, *Jesus... I can't take you anywhere.* But I knew what I was doing.

"OK, don't all go write about how I bitched that Jen was robbed and Josie's win was a sham because that's not what I said."

That earned me another laugh and got things back on track.

"Josie is a terrific fighter. She's had a long hard road, and she's overcome a lot of obstacles most fighters don't have to face. But I think that background and her reputation gave Jen a little bit of a hill to climb as far as the decision went. And maybe that's how it should be. Josie fought a great fight. I guess my point is I feel like Jen did, too."

It was still a bit of a risky thing to say, but I felt it was important for Jen to hear me say it. I was also pretty confident it wouldn't come back on me. This kind of politely sticking up for my fighters is something I'm

known for, and I always say my piece and move on. As long as I didn't make a federal case out of it, no one else would, either.

Of course, there were a few reporters that tried to goad me down that road. But once it became clear I had no more to say, the session petered out. Then we got two for the price of the one as Diana Dahlgren and Catherine Bell took center stage.

Steph and I could have taken a nap during that one because our presence wasn't needed. Cat's slow and stealthy take over of the heavyweight division had long ago made her a press favorite, and now they had Dianna's crazy, unexpected performance here to chew on, as well.

On top of all that, the two of them have developed a genuine mentor-mentee affection for each other that's fun to witness. The reporters in the room couldn't get enough of them. And it didn't hurt that Dianna was taking her loss in stride.

"I knew what I was up against," the former fitness model said, "but I really wanted to give her something. To push her, at least a little, ya' know? Let the teacher know the student was coming. That kind of thing."

At that point, Cat reached over and playfully tousled the blonde's thick mane.

"Get outta here, little girl," she teased. "You ain't got nothing for me."

When the laughter died down, Bell gave a more sincere appraisal of her teammate's performance.

"She has a lot to be proud of," the JAG actress said. "It's hard to win in this league, and it's a lot harder to do it consistently. I think I know that better than most. But if you're gonna do it, you have to start somewhere. And this feels like just the beginning, for her."

Steph and I just nodded along. What was there to say? The present and future of RSI's heavyweight group were both sitting elbow to elbow at that table, and everyone in the room knew it. Our job was to not say anything stupid, which we did quite well.

Next up, Daniela Hantuchova... who somehow seemed to be the past, present and future of our light heavyweight group, all rolled into one. So mature... so polished... so accomplished... and showing absolutely no signs of slowing down. She had faced-down three outstanding fighters in this tournament. Two of them long-time divisional champions. And yet, no one had really given any of them a credible chance against Daniela... because she is simply that good.

Even more amazing... she has no clue. One reporter asked for her thoughts on her career as a whole, specifically wondering how she manages to keep beating such skilled opponents.

Daniela looked at him like he'd asked how she remembered to keep breathing every day.

"I just do," she said.

The reporter obviously wanted more, but Hantuchova had nothing for him.

Steph stepped in to fill the void.

"The simple truth is that no one outworks Daniela. Not in the gym. Not in the cage. And it's not just her physical abilities. She's always thinking. Always planning. Always a step ahead. She's got all the tools, including the ones you just can't teach."

For my part, I just stuck with the nodding. It seemed to be working so far.

Next in the chair was Torrie Wilson. Given the awful way her fight had ended, this one had the potential to be a sob-fest. But she proved to be a good sport about the whole thing, and she set the tone early.

A good repair job can minimize the appearance of many injuries. Torrie wasn't so lucky. Her broken pinkie had been splinted to its neighbor, then wrapped in a cast that went all the way to the middle of her forearm. It was impossible to miss.

Upon sitting down, she held it out in front of her like a club and said, "Come get me now, Maria."

After that, the conversation was all about disappointment. Not over the lost championship because Torrie had the confidence to know she had plenty more title fights in her future. But she was pretty bummed about missing the chance to really throw down with Sharapova.

"It felt like we were headed for something special," Wilson said, "and then..."

She held the injured hand up again and said, "I don't even know how the hell this happened."

Steph and I added a few comments, but the theme was the same. It was a crappy way to end what was shaping up to be a great fight, and that was pretty much all there was to say.

Out went Torrie. In came Emily.

Despite the savagery she can produce inside the cage, Em's typical demeanor would best be described as *sweet as pie*. She is also very press-friendly.

Well... except for that reporter she ripped to shreds.

OK, so it's more of a rhubarb pie. Thoroughly enjoyable, unless it's made wrong and then it kills you.

Funny thing, though... I think that episode sort of defined her in the eyes of the media. She's never asked for special treatment, and she's willing to answer the hard questions. But she demands respect - for every fighter, not just herself. Once that was understood... well, I think they actually find her fun to talk to.

Tonight was no exception. With very little prompting, she hit all the right notes. How great it feels to win. That, no matter how many titles she reels in, the feeling never changes. She gave credit to Larter,

recognizing her as a tough opponent who just keeps getting better and better. She expressed gratitude for the team she had behind her, and included specific nods to Steph, Danni and even me.

I know... it all sounds like standard, pat answers. And probably that's exactly what they are. But coming from Emily... it all just seems so genuine.

Meanwhile, Steph and I had very little to offer. It's like I said... when it comes to Emily, I've already said it all. Even the reporters seemed to be fishing for something new. Pushing a little deeper in an effort to find some new details to write about.

They found what they were looking for when one asked Steph what it was like to work with Emily during the breaks.

"Emily is very different," she said. "The best fighters are very receptive in the corner. They listen and understand. They can visualize what you're saying, and then they go out and execute. But there's a rare sort of interplay with Emily because she's more proactive. I find she has a deeper understanding of the game. She doesn't just receive strategy. She helps create it."

It was quite a statement, all on it's own. Couple it with the way Steph had moved aside to let Emily coach Zendaya, and it really makes you think.

With the media's appetite satisfied, the session quickly wound down. Which brought us to Emma, who was accompanied by Tiffany.

Things got started with the typical questions regarding how it felt for her to get a win of this magnitude. That was quickly followed by another about how it felt to be dogged for so long by the doubters.

Funny thing about questions like that... they come with nearly obligatory answers. And they're never the ones you really wanted to give.

Instead of wondering aloud about why the doubts ever existed and who the hell it was that decided when you were *proven*, Ms. Watson stuck to the script - talking about the faith she had in herself, and the help she'd had in getting here.

Meanwhile, everyone in the room knew we were just beating around the bush.

Sure, Emma's complete and convincing victory was worth some conversation. The question of whether or not she was now one of the established elite was also a worthy topic of discussion. But what they really wanted to talk about it was the way she'd taken her sweet time beating Nadine Coyle's insides out.

After a few more perfunctory questions, the boom was lowered by one of the reporters in the front row.

"There's been some conversation about the length of the fight," he said. "Nadine has something of a reputation, and one theory that's been discussed is that you might have dragged things out to give her some payback."

I felt myself tense. It didn't matter how many people approved of what Emma had done. There would always be some that didn't, and still others that simply lived to cause trouble. Things were going to get pretty ugly if it wasn't handled properly.

I had every confidence that Emma could handle it, but it turned out she didn't have to.

"Nadine is a dangerous fighter, and she can take over a fight very quickly," Steph cut in. "She is also someone RSI fighters have to face quite a bit. I've spent a lot of time reviewing film and game-planning ways to beat her. Emma has the skills to make those things work, and she did a great job. She had a lot of success with it, which allowed us to take a much more patient approach after that. We wanted to keep the pressure on, while also staying cautious. I didn't want to give Nadine a chance to get back in the fight."

It was no surprise to me that Steph was willing to take this bullet. Like I said, we *all* agreed with what Emma did. And Steph even found a way to say so.

"You're saying the strategy we saw came from you?" the reporter asked.

"Of course it did," she answered. "That's why I'm here."

Then she looked at Emma and added, "I'm proud of the way it worked out, too."

Em gave her the smirk, and a little nod of gratitude. Both for the cover, and for the message of support that had come with it.

Meanwhile, the nature of Steph's response left the reporters in a tough spot. I'm sure most assumed it was bullshit, but it was also direct and comprehensive. People were going to say whatever they were going to say, but Steph had given her answer and she wasn't going to change it. You either had to accept it at face value, or completely dispute it. And there is something about Steph that firmly discourages dispute.

The session started to drift a bit. A few specific questions were asked about the way the fight played out. Half-hearted attempts to pick at the edges and see if they could get the revenge discussion going again. But Emma easily brushed them all aside with concise answers. Just the facts, presented in a way that fit with Steph's explanation. Case closed.

And, since no one apparently had anything else to do...

"My question is for Richelle," Rachel Nichols began. "In your magazine write-up for the last team event, you had some comments about Emma's chances at this tournament..."

"Ah, geez..." I moaned. "Did you have to bring *THAT* up? I mean... I think Em was just gonna let it go, but now..."

"The hell I was," Emma said.

Another good laugh was had - this time at my expense. And just as it died away...

"Well? We're all waiting," Emma prompted.

She had a very smug look on her face, which I gave right back to her.

"Kiss it, Watson."

More laughter. Maybe RSI should think about sponsoring a comedy tour on the side.

I squared up to the microphone and got serious.

"First of all, I think everyone knows that giving Emma a hard time is an unofficial part of my job. I'd also like to point out that she seems to have put herself in charge of driving me crazy, too."

"I'll cop to that," Emma chimed in.

"Point is, I never would have made those comments if I really felt that way. But I said what I said, and I'll take whatever I have coming to me."

Emma started to respond, but I held up a hand.

"As for how I really feel," I continued, "some might disagree..."

I motioned toward Tiff.

"...some from my own stable, as a matter of fact... but I think there's an argument to be made that Emma is the best featherweight in the league."

The stir that caused was minor. Which was a good thing. It told me that the earlier questions weren't just lip-service. They were truly and finally starting to appreciate what Em was capable of.

"I know there are other names in that conversation. Like I said, one of them is sitting right here. Publicly speaking, Emma's been on the fringe of the discussion for a while, and I think she made quite a statement here tonight. But she proved herself to me a long time ago. She says she never doubted herself, and I never doubted her either."

Then I gave Em a stern look and said, "And she damn-well knows that."

She nodded lightly. Again, she moved to speak, but I had more.

"I also need to point out that what you see from her in the cage is just the surface. We see so much more behind the scenes. She's always there for her teammates, and she's been a huge help with our younger talent. There's really no way for me to quantify what she brings to the organization."

Realizing I had wandered off into the deep end a bit, I searched for a way to bring it all home.

"Danni is our leader. Steph is in charge of the strategy. RSI couldn't survive without either of them. But time and experience have taught all three of us that it sometimes takes more than we can give. When we need more, Emma is one of the first people we turn to. And we keep doing it because she keeps coming through. Simple as that."

Emma and I shared another look as I waited for her response.

"That's really sweet," she said, and she did look truly touched.

But then...

"It's not going to get you off the hook, though."

Laughter broke out again.

"I never thought it would, Em," I said. "I never thought it would."

A few more questions followed. Despite what she said, she never fired another heavy shot. We entertained the masses with a few more light jabs at each other, and then the session came to a close.

Maybe she let me off easy, after all. Or maybe she was saving it for later?

Made no difference to me. If we weren't torturing each other over this, then there'd just be something else.

Danni entered as Emma and Tiffany got up to leave. It was the first chance they'd had to really talk since the tournament ended, and they stopped to take a private moment right there in the middle of the room.

Though there wasn't much to it, the moment struck a chord with me. They hugged and celebrated and talked a bit, all the while acting as if the rest of us weren't there.

I was proud to see them do it. Media sessions are an important part of the job, but nothing should be more important than your friends and teammates.

Danni continued to the front, and I felt that little pull again. I'd had plenty of time to cool down since our encounter in the training room, but I could feel things warming up again. For example, she was wearing the exact same red-on-black *Rampage Sports* t-shirt that every other fighter had worn, but it looked ten times better on her.

Was that really true?

In the reality I was living in, it sure as hell was.

I wondered if things would ever be the way they were - where Danni and I could be in the same place without this electrical charge in the air.

I sort of hoped the answer was no.

I watched her all the way in. I noticed everything... and it all pointed to just how comfortable she was. The easy elegance of her stride. The gentleness of her smile... it's authenticity proven by the way her eyes smiled, as well.

It was much the same as it had been that night in her kitchen. Every movement she made seemed to happen for me in slow-motion perfection. Every tiny detail accentuated and magnified.

The difference between then and now was me. What happened that night had frightened me, but I wasn't scared of anything, now.

You're worthy because I said so.

Nonsense. I wasn't worthy. I was lucky. And that was good enough for me.

I blew a quiet sigh between my lips as I realized the pull had carried me away and I'd forgotten where I was, again.

If it was always going to be this way, then I was going to have to learn to handle it better.

Danni took her seat and the session got started. The first question posed to her was exactly the same as it was for all the others.

"Can you talk a little about your feelings on the win?"

Danni's answer was the same, too.

"It always feels great to win."

After that, things got more specific. And it started with Rachel Nichols.

"You showed a remarkable ability to fight out of the southpaw stance tonight, which is not something you've done much in the past. Is that a technique you've been working on?"

"It is," Danni answered. "It started out as something I was just fooling around with, but - with the help of some of my teammates - I started to get pretty good at it. And it sure came in handy tonight."

Now I was a teammate. Quite a demotion... yet it sounded like a compliment to me.

Meanwhile, it's funny... Danni is so careful about protecting everyone else. So diligent about respecting her opponents. But she did a lousy job of shielding herself from what was coming next.

"Is there some reason you didn't use it earlier in the fight?"

You could almost hear the question bounce off her skull like a rock. Her mouth hung partially open and her face went blank.

What was she supposed to say?

Because I'm an obstinate pain in the ass.

That might be a little too honest, even for her. But Steph and I had seen this one coming, and our chief strategist was there to make the save.

"As Danni said, this is something new for her. Now, I'm not going to lie... I saw what you saw. She's very good at it. One of the best I've seen, actually. But she's still not completely comfortable with it, so it was not something we planned to introduce tonight. You saw it late because we realized it was the best way to counter what Cheryl was doing."

That kicked the door down for the reporters to get into Cole's gameplan. Which was an intentional act. We knew it would be discussed, so we might as well decide when it was going to happen.

The subject was broached immediately by a reporter in the middle of the group.

"A lot is being made of the tactics Cheryl used tonight. I was wondering if you could talk a little about that."

Danni being Danni, she shrugged like she didn't even understand why the question had been asked.

"Cheryl and her team came up with a plan, and she went out and executed. And you have to give her credit... it was extremely effective early."

You see what I mean about the high road? I mean, the air has to be pretty thin up there, no? I wonder if she sometimes finds it hard to breathe.

Cole deserved to get thoroughly dragged for what she did. Danni could have at least given her a little skewering.

Unsatisfied with the deliberately unsatisfactory answer, the reporter turned his question on Steph.

"Strategy is key at this level," she said. "You can't just bully your way through a fight. You have to know what you can do, and what your opponent can do. Then you figure out how to maximize your advantages while minimizing hers. It's a complicated thing. Sometimes there are things you do well that also open up opportunities for her. You have to figure out how to make it all work without leaving yourself vulnerable. In the end, you keep the things you think you can do safely and drop the stuff you know will get you in trouble. That's what Cheryl did here."

The long and somewhat circular response left the reporter's head doing a sort of dazed wobble on top of his neck. You could tell he wanted to follow-up, but he wasn't sure where to even start. No one else seemed to know how to go about it, either.

I, on the other hand, was struggling not to laugh.

I wondered if any of them realized she'd said exactly what they wanted her to. She'd blunted the impact by talking around it a little, but boil the quote down and you get...

By the time Cole got done eliminating the things Danni could beat her at, she didn't have anything left.

Still... no reporter wants to work to create controversy. I'm sure they would have preferred one of us call Cheryl a scared little bitch. But no one came up with a different way to go after the subject, so the discussion drifted in a new direction.

"After the way your last fight with Cheryl turned out, there was a lot of talk about what it meant for your career. Do you feel the win tonight proves the doubters wrong?"

"I'm done talking about last time," Danni said. "I've already admitted I wasn't at all satisfied with that performance, and that's all I've got to say. As for the talk that followed... I mean, I heard most of it, but I didn't pay much attention. I knew I was still capable of fighting at this level, and I had the right people around to remind me of that, every day. Is there any vindication in tonight's win? I'd be lying if I said no, but I don't feel this tremendous sense of relief. It always feels good to get a win, but the result doesn't surprise me."

She paused there, then thought of something else to add.

"If anything, I'm hopeful this means my teammates can stop answering questions about my future. They've been squarely behind me the whole time, and I can't thank them enough for that. But there's no reason for me to be a topic of discussion every time they get a microphone shoved in their face. So, maybe this means that will stop."

Though her wording was a little sharp, her tone was flat and unreadable. Was she chastising the media for badgering her teammates? Pleading with them to stop? Or maybe just acknowledging the support her friends had given her?

My best guess was all of the above, but it was delivered in a way that left no bad taste.

Nichols followed up with another question about Cole.

"Cheryl made quite a few comments after the last fight," she said. "You seemed reluctant to respond at the time. Anything to say, now?"

"I wasn't reluctant," Danni answered. "I wanted my response to come in the cage, and my message has been delivered."

Geez... she stuck the knife right in and gave it a twist. All done in one move. All with that happy, innocent smile on her face.

As if I needed another reason to love her.

The group pressed her a bit, but she gave them nothing more. Cole had done her talking. Danni had answered with her fists. Nothing she could say now was going to top that.

Steph and I had nothing to add, either. In fact, I had been silent since the session started. But that changed when Nichols circled the conversation back to the nature of the help Danni had gotten from her teammates.

The RSI team leader paused a moment before she responded.

"I don't know how to answer that question because it's been so widespread. Just the way they've constantly been there, at every turn. It was truly invaluable, and I'll never be able to repay them for it. But it's hard to explain."

"I'll take a shot at it," I interjected.

I felt Danni's eyes click over to me, and I could see the *don't-you-dare* expression on her face without looking. I paid no attention to her.

"First of all, there's nothing for Danni to repay because her teammates were already repaying what she's done for them. And I say that without reservation, on behalf of every single member of *Rampage Sports*."

Danni pushed my elbow a bit with hers, but I ignored that, too.

"As you can see, she doesn't want me to talk about this. Which is no surprise to anyone that knows her. But you don't have to take my word for anything. If you want, I can line up the whole stable right here, and they can each tell you what Danni means to them. Each would tell some version of the same story, too. About how Danni is always willing to take time out to help with whatever is needed. They would talk about the environment she fosters, and the way she invests herself in their careers."

She did the elbow thing again. I nudged her back and gave her a hard look.

"I'm doing this," I said, "so quit trying to stop me."

Having this play out live and right in front of media probably wasn't smart... not to mention that I didn't know what 'doing this' meant because I didn't know exactly where I was going with this little presentation. But none of that seemed to stop me.

"I'm not going to tear down and examine everything Danni does because we would literally be here FOREVER... but what I don't think she understands is the way her approach carries forward. The women of RSI look out for each other. They not only want to succeed, but they want their teammates to succeed, too. Hell... I have fighters in the same division - competing for the same title - who worry as much about each other as they do about themselves."

I turned a little and looked at Danni.

"You'll deny this, but I'm convinced the reason that happens is because they learned it from you. That's especially true of the younger fighters. They see the way you are in the gym. They see the way you carry yourself in the cage, and in general. And I think they tell themselves, *Yeah... that's the kind of champion I want to be.*"

"Now, you're really being ridiculous," Danni said.

"Am I?" I asked. "Well maybe me should just take it from the top and see how it all plays out."

Then I turned my full attention back to the press and said, "Let me tell you the story of how it all began."

"Oh, c'mon..." Danni pleaded, but I just kept going.

"Six years ago, I had little more than a vague idea of what I wanted this stable to be. I didn't know where to start or who to sign, or anything. I decided step one was to get myself a team leader. And surprise, surprise... I didn't know how to do that, either."

The laughter started again, and I was kind of feeling it. It had been a great night, and it was only going to get better. For the first time in a long time, I felt like I had the world on a string.

"I start interviewing people, and I'm just winging it. I mean, how do I know what makes a good leader? So, I'm just asking questions, and scribbling down notes like they mean something, all the while thinking I'm going to end up throwing a dart at a board and that's how I'm going to make my choice."

More laughter. Vegas, here I come.

"In walks Danni, looking almost as clueless as I was. Like she had no real interest in the job, and didn't even know why I'd bothered to call her..."

"I didn't," she admitted.

"And she's all laid-back in her jeans and that leather jacket. Ohhh my god... that leather jacket."

"Stop," she said, but she was laughing now, too.

"So, I'm thinking, *finally... here's one I can just eliminate from the list.*"

"You did not."

"I absolutely did. I mean, I already didn't know anything. I didn't need to hire somebody else so we could not know anything, together."

She shrugged as if to say, *That's fair*.

"So, this is a no-go right off the bat," I continue, "but I still have to do the interview. So, we sit and I'm running through my questions. And they're stupid questions I grabbed off the internet, so, you know... we're not learning much. But then I come to one of the most basic... *How do you view the role of a stable leader?*"

The laughter in the room died down.

"And I mean... I'd already heard all the answers you'd expect about providing a positive environment and maintaining an effective training regimen."

The laughter stopped completely. Something good was coming, and they knew it.

"But Danni just says, *I don't know*. Which was just about the only wrong answer you could give. But then I look over and she's got this look on her face like she's really thinking it over. So, I wait her out, but instead of answering she turns it back on me and asks how I plan to put the roster together. And now I'm the one saying I don't know, and she says - and this is a quote - 'How can I tell you what my role would be when you can't tell me who the hell I'll be leading?' Just like that. With a look on her face that says, *Exactly how dumb are you?*"

The laughter returned, with Danni and I laughing right along. Even Steph cracked a smile.

The group in front of us had transformed into an audience instead of a media gaggle, and we were just two friends telling a story.

"So, now I'm thinking, *Who the hell is this chick talking to?*" I continued.

"And then you threw the pad at me," Danni said.

"I tossed it," I corrected, "along with a pen. And with a real bad attitude, I say, 'If you know everything, then show me.' At which point, she should have told me to go fly a kite, but no... she starts jotting down ideas. Stuff about balance between veterans and newer talent, and what we're going to need if I really want this to work right. Then she asks for a list of available free agents."

"Which you also threw at me."

I stopped and looked at her.

"You can't throw a piece of paper."

"It was multiple sheets stapled together."

"Still... I didn't throw it at you."

"You most certainly did."

"Whatever," I said. "So she looks it over and she's tossing out names and ideas, and I'm adding my two cents, and it's literally turned into an argument."

"You mean like this?"

"No, not like this. We've had years of practice. We're much better at it, now."

She thought about that, then said, "I really can't disagree."

"Sure you can. It's what you do."

Now I was just being a deliberate pain, so she stopped and gave me a sly smile.

"This is going to get out of hand if you don't get to your point," she said.

Fair enough.

"It's not a point so much as a question... when did I hire you?"

The sly smile transformed into a bemused grin. Like, *Really? We went through all this just for that?*

"I'm serious," I said. "I remember, somewhere in the middle of everything, thinking, *What the hell happened here? Wasn't this supposed to be an interview?*, but I don't remember offering you the job."

She gave that some thought, expecting the answer to come simply enough. Then the grin went away as she realized that wasn't going to happen.

"I remember you saying something like, 'Are you coming back tomorrow, or what?'"

"Sure," I said. "At that point, you were working for free. Why would I pass that up? But did I ever formally offer you the position?"

She thought some more.

"I don't think so."

"Well then, there you have it," I said. "Danni showed up, pissed me off and then never left."

The group was practically in stitches, and everyone was looking to Danni for a rebuttal that never came.

"I want to argue," she said, "but I think that's pretty much what happened."

"Well, I assume we worked it out," I said, "and whatever I'm paying you, it's a steal."

My serious tone sobered the group up immediately. Leave it to Richelle to ruin the party.

I kept my focus on Danni.

"I'm not going to sit here and claim you deserve credit for everything RSI has accomplished," I continued. "Steph, here... there are so many things we've done that wouldn't have happened without her. Emma, Tiff, Emily... so many people deserve credit. But it all circles back to you, in the end."

I don't know how I did it, but it seemed I'd finally shut her up. She didn't even try to argue. In fact, my quick change in direction seemed to have caught her flat-footed.

"One of your teammates once said to me... 'Danni always puts herself last.'," I continued. "And it's true. It's been true since the minute I met you. Always thinking about what you need to do for everybody else. Where you need to get involved, and when you need to stay out of the way. And you never seem to get it wrong."

The color was steadily rising in her face, and you could see she was getting flustered.

"Stop," she said. "Seriously, stop."

"Alright... I'll make you a deal. I'll stop, if you promise one thing. For me, and all your teammates. Never say again that you owe us anything."

She shook her head... still tear free, but clearly emotional. I had really gotten her good.

"I hate you for doing this to me," she said.

Doing this to me.

Like I'd made it all up just to embarrass her.

"I'm only giving you what you deserve."

I looked to Steph for support, and got a steady nod.

"Fine," Danni said. "Now, I hate you both."

"We can live with that," Steph said.

Danni sat back and looked off over the top of the crowd in front of her. She never said another word, but a single, tiny tear slipped out of the corner of her eye.

"I think we have a deal," I announced.

* * *

The session broke up shortly after that, and Danni pulled me aside at the first opportunity.

"I wish you hadn't done that," she said.

"That's why I did it. You're just lucky I let you off easy."

She didn't say anything, but I took a few steps back to put some distance between us.

"Where are you going?"

"Don't know," I admitted. "Out for a walk, I guess. I just... I need to be somewhere else."

I took a few more steps.

"Richelle, you can't..."

"Danni, I have to."

She just looked at me.

"You're worried," I said. "That's fair. I've given you plenty of reason to recently. I've been an emotional mess. But this isn't that. This is about me jumping you right here in front of all these people if I don't get away from you."

Her mouth opened, then closed. Her expression hardened and her eyes drifted, and I knew she was running through her options. Trying to think of a place we could go with a door we could lock. But the look went away as she came up empty. There was no such place and too many people would be looking for her. There was no doubt her teammates were back in the locker room right now, ready to celebrate. And there was no way they would take no for an answer.

Instead, I was given a warning.

"You make a remark like that," she said, "you'd better be prepared to back it up."

"Soonest opportunity I get," I said.

I turned and left before she could say another word.